“Is that so?” He shook his head. “Pen and paper serve me just fine.”

“Typing was my profession. I’m quite fast—eighty words a minute.”

“Impressive. I write daily reports for all the patients in the sick bay, including their names, medical condition, and expected return-to-work dates. Every report must be typed. Unfortunately, my fingers fumble and get caught between the keys!” He held out his hands. “Maybe they’re just too big.”

“You’ll get better with practice.”

“My problem is time; there isn’t enough of it,” he said, rubbing his forehead. “And what would have taken one hour to write a report by hand now takes two or three because of that clunky machine. Never mind.”

He bent down and opened a drawer, lifting a glass jar out of it before glancing back at her.

“Here you go. Euphrasia.”

He unscrewed the jar and held it up for her to see. The gray paste inside had a mild grassy scent. He closed the jar and placed it in a paper bag with a square of cheesecloth, a ribbon and a piece of paper with German writing.

“Tell your friend to dampen the cheesecloth, take some of the paste and wrap it inside, then tie it and rest it on her eye. I’ve written down the instructions in German for her.”

“Thank you. How much should I pay you?”

He waved a hand in the air. “Nothing.”

“Please, allow me to compensate you for your time. You just said you don’t have enough time and you’ve kindly given me some.” Since the war started three years ago, she’d yet to meet a single person who did something without expecting payment in return.

“Euphrasia grows in the forests and grasses not far from here. We pick it for free in the spring and summer, then dry it for use over winter. It cost me nothing. Remind your friend to keep her eye closed for a few hours each day, and it will swiftly heal on its own.”

With a relaxed motion, he leaned against the table and crossed his legs. “We haven’t been properly introduced. I’m Josef. And you are?”

“Léa.” Though he spoke fluently, she heard a foreign accent. “How did you learn to speak French like a native speaker?”

“I’m from the Protectorate of Bohemia and Moravia.”

Léa frowned, her cheeks warming with embarrassment. She didn’t